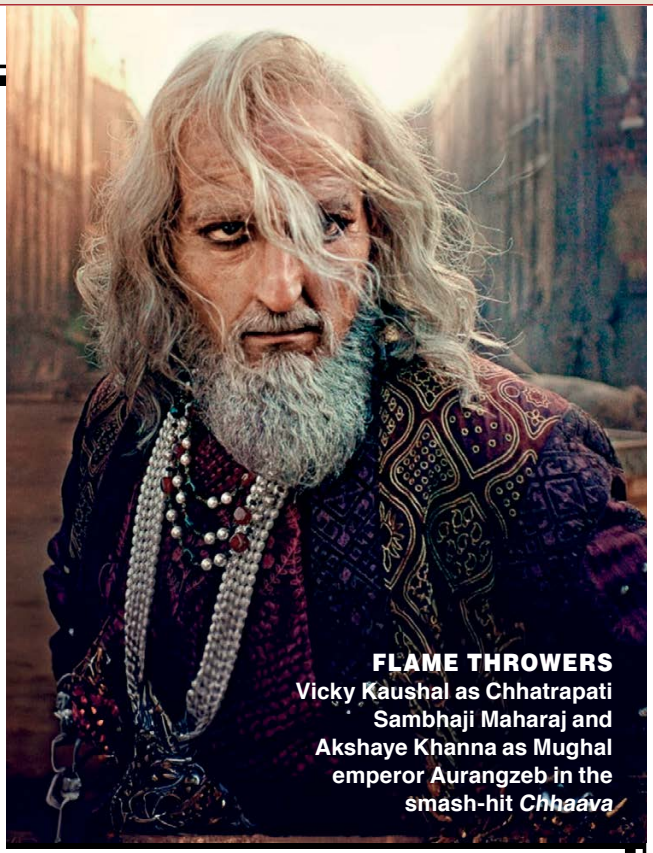


FLAME THROWERS Vicky Kaushal as Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj and Akshaye Khanna as Mughal emperor Aurangzeb in the smash-hit *Chhaava*

graphed action and nationalism, but with mixed results—Kangana Ranaut's *Manikarnika: The Queen of Jhansi* clicked while others like Akshay Kumar's *Samrat Prithviraj* tanked.

Chhaava is not the first high-octane Hindi film about Maratha valour. In 2019, Gowariker's ill-fated *Panipat* was followed by *Tanhaji—The Unsung Warrior* with Ajay Devgn in the lead. Directed by Om Raut, it netted Rs 270 crore. "As filmmakers, it's our job to tell stories of lesser-known individuals whose sacrifices we don't know of and explore intricacies of their personalities," says Raut. After *Chhaava*'s success, Raut senses more conversation on Indian history in the film industry. "Today we go to cinemas for large-scale extravaganza," he says. "That's why historical films come into focus. They inject pride and nationalism, you get inspired, learn not to repeat mistakes from the past and move forward."

Savarkar speaks of how lives of other figures in Maratha history are ripe for larger-than-life treatment, citing Santaji Ghorpade, Tanhaji Jadhav and Tarabai. "If anybody wants to do it, I am very much interested," he says. ■

On March 17, the Sambhal administration, led by Assistant Superintendent of Police (ASP) Shrish Chandra, denied permission for the Neja Mela, scheduled for March 25-27. The decision followed discussions with the Neja Mela Committee, during which objections were raised about honouring Ghazi. "History bears witness that he was a commander under Mahmud of Ghazni. He looted Somnath, massacred people across the nation. No festival will be held in memory of such a looter," Chandra said. He warned that any attempt to raise the Neja flag would be considered an "anti-national act" and met with strict action.

The ban sparked outrage among members of the Neja Mela Committee and political leaders, who saw it as an infringement on religious traditions. SP MP Zia Ur Rehman Barq strongly opposed the ban, defending Ghazi's legacy. "It's historically inaccurate to link him to the Somnath attack in 1026 CE, as Ghazi was only 11 years old at the time. Historians find no evidence of his involvement. He was a revered Sufi saint who fought oppression and served humanity, not an invader," he said. The ban in Sambhal emboldened Hindu groups in Bahraich and Bhadohi, which submitted memoranda on March 23, urging similar prohibitions. Incidentally, Ghazi's dargah in Bahraich has traditionally been a site of syncretic worship by both, Hindus and Muslims. The VHP and other organisations alleged that the Neja Mela encouraged land encroachment and illegal conversions.

THE HINDUTVA PROJECT, SAY ITS CRITICS, IS NOT BOUND BY HISTORICAL AUTHENTICITY BUT DEPENDS ON CONSTANT AROUSAL OF PASSIONATE RAGE

Whose History Is It Anyway?

History, asserts author Nilanjan Mukhopadhyay, is being used as a clear tool for the enhancement of majoritarian politics. "We in India have been witnessing the harnessing of history to create public anger," he says, adding that it was most evident during the Ram temple movement of the mid-'80s. "The political message is clear—Hindus are the *nation* here, all others, particularly the Muslims, can live only as a matter of grace, not as a matter of right," says Purushottam Agrawal.

So, whether in Maharashtra or Uttar Pradesh—two of India's most powerful states that send 48 and 80 legislators, respectively, to the Lok Sabha—Hindutva groups are raking up India's medieval past to whip up public sentiment against everything Islamic or Islamicate. Medieval rulers are branded as villains, even if truth is seldom linear, or black and white. There is no room for nuance or complexity. Author and retired IAS officer Vishwas Patil asserts, "History is not a slave to anyone but is based on factual realities." He cites instances of Muslim kings giving endowments to Hindu institutions, and vice versa. "After killing (the Adilshahi general) Afzal Khan, Shivaji Maharaj provided land for his tomb and ensured its upkeep from his own purse. Shivaji Maharaj's father Shahaji and uncle Sharifji were named after the Sufi saint Shah Sharif, whose